

HOUSING AND URBAN ISSUES

Transit Crime Phobia and Statistical Reality

The risk of being victimized on a train or a bus is low, but riders' fears are something transit systems need to take seriously.

OPINION | June 17, 2026 • Alan Ehrenhalt



Subway riders in New York City. So far this year there have been four homicides in and around the city's subway system. (Adobe Stock)

One thing we humans are consistently bad at is evaluating risk. We spend an inordinate amount of time worrying about misfortunes that are extremely unlikely to occur and ignoring common risks that happen often.

We worry about commercial airplane crashes even though years and millions of people fly across the United States without even one taking place. We worry about our children being kidnapped even though virtually all child abductions are carried out by relatives of the child. Or we ignore the risk of automobile accidents, which kill tens of thousands of people each year.

And we worry about being attacked on a bus or subway train, which statistics show happens to very few

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people, given the number of passengers these vehicles carry. Although exaggerated, these concerns are perhaps understandable. Getting approached by a robber or mugger in a confined place is a legitimately frightening experience, one that we can be excused for fantasizing about, even though the numbers show that the risk of encountering one of these villains is in fact remarkably low.

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So when a particularly gruesome crime takes place on a bus or train, or on a subway platform, the popular media go to considerable trouble to scare us. When transit crime in New York City worsened for a brief period early this year, a *New York Post* headline **blared** about “RAIL DANGER.” It did much the same thing this month when an elderly man was pushed to his death down subway stairs, describing the alleged assailant as **a “maniac.”** So far this year there have been four homicides in and around the city’s subways, up from just one last year. It’s legitimate to grieve over these events, but it’s also legitimate to place them in comparison to the much larger number of deaths on the city’s streets and highways over the same period.

The truth is that transit crime did spike for a brief period in New York earlier this year, when vagrants were allowed to stay inside stations and trains due to the extreme cold temperatures outside. But once the weather improved, the numbers bounced back to roughly where they were last year. There was no transit crime crisis.

What the numbers do show, if you are willing to look at some recent history, is that transit crime in New York has been on a downward trajectory for most of the past decade. Transit crimes **declined by 14.4 percent** between 2019 and 2025. Overall crime on the subways in 2025 recorded its lowest rate in 16 years. The numbers for 2026, even with the brief wintertime surge, are almost exactly what they were last year. That’s no reason to ignore them. It’s just a reason to apply some perspective.

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One thing we know, thanks to **some diligent research** by the nonprofit group **How Safe Is My Ride?**, that crime, time and place within the New York transit system make a great deal of difference. Crime rates are as much as 25 times higher in the overnight and early morning hours than during the midday and evening rush. They are worst at small subway stations with low ridership. That should not come as much of a surprise, but here’s a nugget that’s interesting: Half of all crimes occur at near just 30 of the system’s 472 stations.

MUCH OF OUR OVERALL CRIME PROBLEM resists easy solutions. The more you invest money and manpower, and you begin to see results. Charlotte, N.C., enhanced security on its trains after a Ukrainian woman was fatally stabbed while sitting on a train. In Los Angeles, assaults on passengers and bus operators **had declined by 67 percent**. That may

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you can't help concluding that enhanced security is something all urban transit systems need to be providing.

Not every city is reaping all the benefits of safe travel. Chicago has seen an increase in aggravated batteries and assaults in its transit system, even as overall crime in the city has been declining. In December, the Federal Transit Administration threatened to withhold \$50 million in grant funding if the situation didn't improve. Since then, the city has increased patrols on its trains, and the Chicago Transit Authority (CTA) called for a 75 percent boost in monthly policing hours. The numbers seem to be getting better, and in March the federal agency backed off its funding threat.

Chicago has always had problems with criminal offenses on its transit system. As far back as the 1960s, the local papers were running headlines with "fear on the CTA" in big type. In the 1990s, the CTA reduced the number of conductors on its trains to help deal with a budget shortage. Crime in the system remained a serious problem. Steps were taken. The number of security cameras was increased. More officers began working overtime in the system. In 2022, new canine patrols were initiated. It remains to be seen whether Chicago can bring in the improvements that other cities seem to be experiencing.

The Washington, D.C., region's Metro system has a different sort of problem. Metro has actually done fairly well in the last few years, boosting its ridership back close to pre-pandemic levels and keeping violent crime more or less under control. But it continues to have trouble with fare evasion — violators who have the nerve and the skill to get through the station turnstiles or bus entry doors without paying for the ride. Metro lost about \$50 million between July 2025 and this March because of bus passengers who don't pay for their rides. It's been estimated that 60 percent of the offenses on Metro are related to fare evasion.

This has as much to do with local politics as it does with law enforcement. The vast majority of fare evaders are African American, and the left-leaning city council has long considered punishing them for such an offense to be a racist act. In 2018, the council essentially decriminalized fare evasion altogether. That resulted in a broad-based citywide backlash, and in 2024 the council responded to it. But pretty tepidly. Within the confines of D.C., fare evasion remains a civil offense carrying a fine of \$50, but now people who are stopped for it and refuse to identify themselves can be arrested. That has helped, but not that much. It's been estimated that nearly 70 percent of Metro bus riders pay by for free; reducing that number is the goal of a recent crackdown.

THERE'S A BIG DIFFERENCE between fare evasion and violent assaults, like locking a turnstile jumper up for a long period of time. But all these offenses are part of a confidence problem. Riders worry about being attacked within a confined space, and they see fare evasion as part of a general epidemic of lawlessness, even if the actual numbers are relatively low and declining. That's something every big-city transit system should be aware of.

Much of the crime that takes place in large cities is difficult for local governments to handle. It isn't one of them. You put two officers on each train between 9 at night and 5 in the morning, and you

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stations better. You install protective barriers on the platforms to make it much harder for a miscreant to push someone onto the tracks. You put in tougher fare gates to deter turnstile jumping, and you pay more attention to people squeezing through the emergency exits.

New York has been doing all these things since 2022, and the results have been generally positive. We will never eliminate the public fears about transit crime, no matter how hard we try or how much the statistics may improve. But we can limit the apprehension customers feel whenever they board a train or bus. As law enforcement goes, that should be low-hanging fruit.

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